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lowest and most despised of the orders, and was subject to legal discrimination; however, wealthy merchants were able to use their financial muscle to become important political players.

Great works

Among Qin Shi Huang's greatest achievements were his ambitious civil engineering projects, although there was a great human cost as many lost their lives in the process. He is traditionally credited with building the first part of the Great Wall of China, to keep out nomadic tribes in the north, by connecting parts of old walls erected by the Warring States and then adding thousands of miles of new wall. Other projects included constructing the Lingqu canal, which linked the Xiang and Li rivers so military supplies could be transported from northern to southern China, and building military roads including "the Straight Road," which was 497 miles (800km) long and ran from Xianyang to the Great Wall.

Most famous of all the emperor's ventures was the construction of his own elaborate mausoleum complex, which took 38 years and over 700,000 workers to construct. It consisted of a giant pyramid covered in earth to create an immense mound, 328ft (100m) high and 1,640ft (500m) across. Within the pyramid was a tomb in which his beloved empire was recreated in

miniature, complete with liquid mercury rivers and seas. Buried around the tomb were large pits filled with thousands of life-size terra-cotta warriors, bureaucrats, and entertainers, all intended to serve the emperor in the afterlife. Workers on the tomb were killed after completing their tasks so the secrets of the mausoleum's location and contents died with them, and the tomb remained undiscovered for over 2,000 years.

Despite the megalomaniacal exertions of the First Emperor, the Qin dynasty was to prove short-lived. Peasant unrest caused by deep-seated resentment over the brutal extortions of money and the many years of forced labor, plus bankruptcy as a result of over-ambitious civil works, combined to undermine the carefully ordered administration of the emperor and his leading counselors, chief among them the chancellor Li Si.

When the First Emperor died in 210 BCE his youngest son, Hu Hai, under the influence of advisor and former tutor Zhao Gao, seized the throne and exiled—and later executed—Li Si. Hu Hai was subsequently murdered after just three years of being in

Guarding the tomb of Emperor Qin Shi Huang, these life-size terra-cotta soldiers were discovered in 1974 by workers digging a well. The figures were originally brightly painted and each has a unique facial expression.

